Chapter 6

RAJPUTS - THE MAHAKSHATRIYAS

"A renascent India, (was) brought by the valour and blood of the heroic Rajputs. A Rajput would rather die than break his promise. For, the stories of Rajput heroes in this kind are endless. You, Rajputs, have been the glories of ancient India."

- Swami Vivekananda



LEARNING OUTCOMES

- Discuss about the reign of the Rajputs and how they ascended to supremacy.
- Assess the role of the valorous Rajput kings and queens in defending Bharat
- Explain the importance of Maharana Pratap in the history of Bharat
- Examine the crucial battles fought by Rana Sangha, Rana Kumba, Rana Pratap, and more against the Mughals

INTRODUCTION

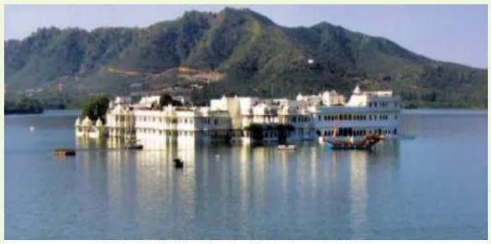
The aggression on Bharat's honour and resources by the invaders was met head-on by many brave warriors. The valorous and heroic Rajputs were one of the most effective and accomplished fighting forces that protected the country from invaders. The fountain of their strength can be traced to their spiritual foundation, the Shakti peeth* of Arbuda Devi in present day Mount Abu. While there are many ancestry lines of Rajputs, they majorly belong to the Ajmeris, Marwaris or Mewaris. The Rajputs of Ajmer and Jaipur were known as Ajmeris. The Marwaris hailed from the Yodhapura (present day Jodhpur) area. The Mewaris descended from the Sisodias. Towards the end of the rule of Alauddin Khalji (1316 CE), many of the independent kingdoms had been absorbed into the Sultanate. However, other Rajput families re-established their kingdoms. Their origins can be traced back to the Pratiharas, Chandelas and Paramaras. In this lesson, we learn about them in detail.

GROWTH OF MEWAR AFTER RANA HAMMIR

After Rana Hammir's death, his son **Kshetrasimha** ascended the throne and ruled for more than 25 years (1378 - 1405 CE). The weakening of Delhi Sultanate after the death of Sultan Firuz Shah Tughluq in 1388 CE allowed Mewar to focus on development the state and its subjects. Kshetrasimha's eldest son Lakshasimha or Laakha succeeded to the throne of Mewar in 1405 CE and ruled for 15 years.

There was boom in trade in the region during this time. Advanced system of weights and measures handled currency. International traders came to the region - one of the traders constructed the artificial lake near Udaipur known today as the Pichhola lake. This strong economic foundation funded Mewar's war campaigns in the 15th & 16th centuries and created great monuments. When the Sultan of Jaunpur imposed

Shakti peeth : A significant place of worship and pilgrimage of Goddess Shakti


Lake Pichhola in Udaipur, Bharat

taxes on pilgrims traveling to sacred places like Gaya, Benares and Prayaag, Laakha sponsored and supported the pilgrims.

Laakha married Hamsabai, daughter of Chunda who was the leader of Marwar state thereby enabling alliance between Sisodias of Mewar and Rathores of Marwar. **Ranamalla** (brother of Hamsabai) joined the court of Laakha and aided him in the activities of the state.

Ranamalla subsequently served as regent* to **Mokal**, son of Laakha in 1420 CE. Later, in 1433 CE, Mokal was killed during a battle against the Sultan of Gujarat. Ranamalla gathered the Rathore army of Marwar, marched to Mewar, expelled Mokal's assassin from Chittor and seated Mokal's son **Kumbha** on the throne. Rana Kumbha was a minor* when he became a king.

This alliance of Mewar and Marwar lasted for 25 years until the assassination of Ranamalla via a conspiracy of a few who didn't want Rathores' control on Sisodias of Mewar.



It's often the internal frictions leading to lack of unity that eventually make a society ripe for external aggressions.



Mewar Region



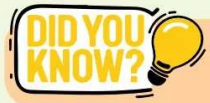
Marwar Region

RENAISSANCE UNDER RANA KUMBHA


Rana Kumbha

Rana Kumbha, one of the greatest rulers of medieval Bharat, was born in the Sisodia clan and ruled Mewar between 1433 and 1468 AD.

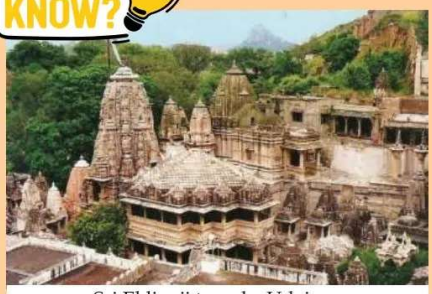
Post the death of Ranamalla, Rana Kumbha was engaged in wars for 7 years with the Rathores on the western front and Mahmud Khalji (Sultan of Malwa) on the southern front. Despite successive efforts by Khalji with the combined army of Malwa and Gujarat, Chittor could not be captured. Traumatized* by these defeats, Khalji didn't attack Mewar for another 10 years since 1446 CE. To commemorate this victory, Rana Kumbha erected the '**Vijay Sthamba**', a 37 m tall monument at Chittorgarh in 1448 AD. A period of peace followed during which Rana Kumbha constructed many temples, buildings and forts.



Rana Kumbha fought 56 wars and remained undefeated in every single one of them.

Regent : Minister/governor **Minor :** Under the age of 10 **Traumatized :** Deeply afraid

DID YOU KNOW?



Sri Eklingji temple, Udaipur

Eklingji (form of Lord Shiva) is considered the ruler of Mewar, and the kings ruled as his representatives. This temple of Eklingji in Udaipur was installed by Bappa Rawal in the 8th century. Despite repeated raids by the invaders and destruction of the original murthi, the Rajput rulers continued to reinstate the Murthi* as it was a symbol of hope and strength. The temple was rebuilt by Hamir Singh in the 14th century and Rana Kumbha in the 15th century. They called themselves the servants of Eklingji. In the 15th century the Malwa Sultanate ruler Ghiyath Shah ransacked the temple. Rana Raimal, son of Rana Kumbha, captured him, demanded a ransom for his release, and rebuilt the temple of the land with that ransom.

CAPTURE OF NAGAUR

After the death of ruler of Nagaur Firuz Khan in 1453-1454, his son Shams Khan sought the help of Rana Kumbha to dethrone his uncle and promised to dismantle fortifications of Nagaur in return. After capturing the throne, Shams Khan went back on his word and sought the help of the Sultan of Gujarat, Qutbuddin. Rana Kumbha waged war against Shams Khan and the Gujarat army, inflicted a crushing defeat and captured Nagaur.

BATTLE OF NAGAUR	
When?	1455 CE
Where?	Nagaur, Rajasthan
Who were the combatants?	
Sisodias of Mewar	Nagaur & Gujarat Sultanate
Who were the commanders?	
Rana Kumbha	Qutbuddin Shams Khan
Outcome : Crushing defeat of Sultanate. Decisive victory of Sisodia empire	
SIGNIFICANCE : Rana Kumbha gained the treasury of the combined opponents	

TREATY OF CHAMPANER AND MEWAR'S RESISTANCE

After suffering defeat at Nagaur, Qutbuddin led another campaign against Mewar in 1455-56 but Rana Kumbha crushed it yet again. Qutbuddin signed a treaty with Sultan Mahmud Khalji of Malwa at Champaner to attack Mewar and divide the spoils among them. All the towns nearby Gujarat were to be attached to the kingdom of Qutbuddin, while the districts of Mewar and Ahiwara should be retained by the Malwa forces.

The Rathore leader Jodha (son of Ranamalla) was hoping he would become the next ruler of Mewar. But Ranamalla helped Kumbha ascend the throne. Hence Jodha sought revenge against Mewar by siding with Gujarat (the enemy camp). However, Rana Kumbha successfully defended Mewar against the multi-directional attack that lasted for 2 years.

Death of Qutbuddin in 1458 and subsequent hostilities between Malwa and Gujarat, brought the most difficult period of Rana Kumbha's life to an end.



CLASSROOM DISCUSSION

What does it take for a leader to defend the country when it is attacked from all sides simultaneously? What role should you play as a citizen of the country that is in the miseries of war?

Murthi : Main deity of the temple

MULTI-FACETED RANA KUMBHA

Despite a large part of his reign was spent in warfare, Rana Kumbha devoted time for the cultivation of arts and literature. Eklingamahatmya, a contemporary work in Sanskrit extolls Rana Kumbha for his proficiency in Vedas, Smritis, Mimamsa, Upanishads, Natya Shastra (Drama), Rajaniti (Politics), Ganita (Mathematics), Vyakarana (Grammar) and Tarka (Logic). He wrote Rasikapriya, a commentary on Jayadeva's Gita Govinda and Chandisatakam. Rana Kumbha also wrote four dramas in different provincial languages.

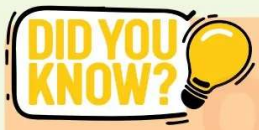


Kumbha Shyam temple, Chittorgarh



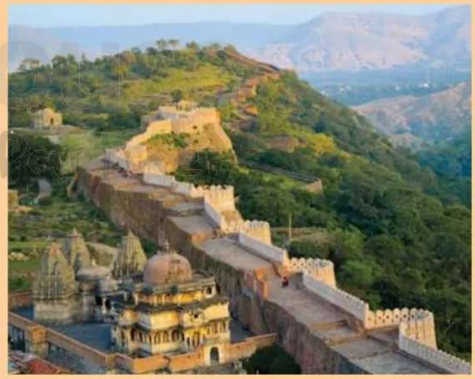
Chittorgarh Fort

Rana Kumbha took keen interest in music. His proficiency can be gauged from his three works on science of music called Sangitaraga, Sangitamimamsa, and Suraprabandha. He built several temples, notable among them being the Kumbha Swamyi and Adivaraha temple. He rebuilt the temple of Eklingji (Shiva) which was partially destroyed. For the purpose of strengthening the defense of his kingdom, Rana Kumbha built several forts like Achalgarh, Chittorgarh, Kumbhalgarh and many more.



Of the 84 fortresses that form the defense of Mewar, 32 were built by Rana Kumbha including the highest fort and most formidable citadel, Kumbhalgarh fort.

Kumbhalgarh fort is 3600 ft tall and a whopping 38 km wide. This citadel located in the western Aravalli hills has the second longest wall after the Great Wall of China.



His exploits on the battleground are peerless. Rana Kumbha was one of the greatest warriors this land has produced who stood for his people, for Dharma and became a symbol of Hindu resistance.

RANA RAYAMALLA'S REIGN

Rana Kumbha suffered a tragic death. He was killed by his eldest son Udaya who was in a hurry to occupy the throne. Even after ascending the throne, Udaya didn't get the approval of the Rajput nobility and was soon dethroned. His younger brother Rayamalla became king.

CHALLENGES

Rana Rayamalla ruled Mewar for 36 years (1473-1509 CE). His immediate challenge was to restore order in the state that was left in chaos under the brief rule of Udaya. Rayamalla's first challenge came from Kshema,

Rana Kumbha's younger brother, who was a lifelong enemy of the latter. Kshema saw an opportunity to assert himself and an intense battle took place at Dadimpur. Kshema was killed and Rayamalla won. Rana Rayamalla's next challenge was the conflict with Malwa. Ghiyasuddin Khalji, son of Mahmud Khalj, advanced to Chittor with his army where a bloody battle took place. The Sultan was defeated and had to retreat. The sultan of Malwa returned to attack Mewar under Zafar Khan. The Rajput army subsequently invaded Malwa. Rayamalla also successfully suppressed the rebellion that arose among the aboriginal tribes.

FIGHT FOR THE THRONE

Rayamalla had 13 sons, the first three in order of seniority being Prithviraj, Jayamalla and Sanga. The three brothers accompanied by their paternal uncle went to a woman named Biri Bai who was revered as Mother Goddess. They asked her as to who will succeed Rayamalla to the throne of Mewar. Biri Bai declared that Sangha would become the King. Enraged, Prithviraj and Jayamalla tried to kill Sangha. Sangha lost his eye but was saved by Surajmalla. Both escaped the kingdom and eventually settled near Ajmer.

Prithviraj became the heir to the throne and handled the administration of the kingdom. He was a gallant prince who fought several battles for Mewar. Unfortunately, towards the end of Rayamalla's reign, the king lost both Prithviraj and Jayamalla. Prithviraj was poisoned by his brother-in-law and Jayamalla died in a battle with a Rajput king. Amidst the gloom, news of Sangha being alive reached Rayamalla's years. Sangha came back to Mewar and ascended the throne in 1509 CE. Rayamalla died soon after.

RANA SANGHA

In 1509 CE, Sangha became the ruler of Mewar. A major part of his youth before becoming the king was spent in anonymity near Ajmer following the feud with Prithviraj. Despite leading a reclusive life, he transformed into one of the most ambitious and aggressive warrior kings to have ruled Mewar.


Rana Sangha

RELATIONSHIP WITH MALWA

When Mahmud Khalji succeeded to the throne, he sought help from Gujarat Sultanate to attack Mandu, capital of Malwa. The Rajput chieftain who was double-crossed by Khalji turned to Rana Sangha for help. By then Mandu was already captured. The Sultan of Gujarat left a part of his army with Mahmud Khalji in Mandu.

Now, Mahmud Khalji wanted to attack the district of Gagraon in 1519 with all his might but he was defeated comprehensively by Rana Sangha. The Sultan himself was captured alive. He was released after 6 months only on the condition that he paid a compensation amount, surrendered the golden heirloom ornaments looted from the Malwas and sent his son as a goodwill ambassador between Malwa and Mewar. In return Rana Sangha let Mahmud Khalji rule over parts of Malwa which belonged to him before the war began. Thus, Rana Sangha put to rest all hostilities with Malwa for the near future.

BATTLE OF GAGRAON	
When? 1519 CE	
Where? Gagraon, Rajasthan	
Who were the combatants?	
Sisodias of Mewar	Malwa, Gujarat Sultanate
Who were the commanders?	
Rana Sangha	Mahmud Khalji
Outcome : Decisive victory for Sisodias	
SIGNIFICANCE : Malwa hostilities resolved	

CLASH BETWEEN MEWAR AND GUJARAT

The Kingdom of Sirohi was in turmoil with two cousins fighting to ascend to the throne. While one of them moved to Rana Sangha's camp by marrying his daughter, the other sought help from the Sultan of Gujarat, thus making Mewar and Gujarat rivals.

Rana Sangha was not only an ace military commander but also a diplomatic leader. Malik Ayaz led the Gujarat army to attack Mewar in 1521. After ransacking many places enroute, the Gujarat army reached the southern frontier of Mewar. Mahmud Khalji of Malwa also joined the Gujarat army.

Rana Sangha appeased the Sultan of Gujarat with gifts and made truce. He cut a deal with Mahmud Khalji by promising to release his son, who had been in his Darbar since 1519. He aggravated the internal politics within Malik Ayaz's regiment to turn them against each other. Thus Rana Sangha won the battle even without having to fight it.

RANA SANGHA DEFEATS IBRAHIM LODI

Rana Sangha shifted his focus to Delhi. In 1517, Ibrahim Lodi became the Sultan of Delhi. It took him 3 years to quell internal rebellions and take control of Delhi. When Sangha and Lodi clashed for the first time in 1517, the Mewar army proved to be too strong for Lodi's army. Rana Sangha was severely injured. He lost an arm to a sword cut while an arrow pierced his leg making him lame for life. Yet it was Mewar's victory.

Ibrahim Lodi again gathered a large army and attacked Mewar. He appointed 3 of his best generals to lead the attack. Lodi doubted one of his generals Husain Khan because of an earlier rebellion and ordered for his arrest. Husain quickly jumped to Rana Sangha's camp, along with a few hundred horsemen. The Rajput army marched forth and confronted the enemy at Dholpur and defeated them decisively. Husain Khan and his contingent however did not participate in this battle. He back-stabbed the Rajputs too. He captured a few war elephants and horses, and escaped. He presented them to Lodi and got accepted back into his fold.

BATTLE OF KHATOLI	
When?	1518 CE
Where?	Khatoli, Rajasthan
Who were the combatants?	
Sisodias of Mewar	Lodi Empire
Who were the commanders?	
Rana Sangha	Ibrahim Lodi
Outcome : Decisive victory for Sisodias	
SIGNIFICANCE : Mewar becomes very powerful in northern Bharat. Lodi fears Sangha.	

The defeat of Ibrahim Lodi was one of the greatest achievements of Rana Sangha. Mewar's boundaries extended till the Bayana river in the north, Raisen in the east, Dungarpur and Banswara in the south. Under Rana Sangha, Mewar became one of the most powerful kingdoms in Northern Bharat. After defeating Ibrahim Lodi, Rana Sangha became a threat to Delhi.

BABUR ESTABLISHES MUGHAL EMPIRE

Arrogance of Ibrahim Lodi and weakening of Delhi Sultanate under him, made him fall out of favor of the Delhi nobility. Ibrahim's uncle Daulat Khan Lodi invited Zahiruddin Babur, Timurid ruler of Kabul to invade Bharat and help get rid of Ibrahim Lodi. Babur readily agreed, but he had other intentions. Unlike previous Mongol invaders who plundered and left the country, Babur harbored a desire to dislodge the Delhi Sultanate and occupy the seat himself.

THE FIRST BATTLE OF PANIPAT, 1526 CE

Babur marched towards Punjab in 1525 CE and occupied Lahore and set up a garrison there. He returned to Kabul to gather reinforcements and returned to lock horns with Ibrahim Lodi who was ready with his army at Panipat in April, 1526 CE. Babur obtained a decisive victory against Lodi and that marked the beginning of the Mughal Empire in Bharat.

FIRST BATTLE OF PANIPAT	
When?	April 1526 CE
Where?	Panipat, Haryana
Who were the combatants?	
Timurids	Delhi Sultanate
Who were the commanders?	
Zahiruddin Babur	Ibrahim Lodi
Outcome : Loss of Delhi Sultanate.	
SIGNIFICANCE : Timurids establish the Timurid dynasty more widely known as Mughal dynasty in Delhi	

Orange House Your Knowledge Partner

BATTLE OF KHANWA

After the battle of Panipat and the fall of Delhi Sultanate, it was clear that Babur meant to stay in Bharat. Rana Sangha's imperial objectives demanded Babur's fledgling Mughal Empire be crushed. The Mewar confederacy included several Rajput Kings of Rajasthan including those of Sirohi, Dungarpur, Chanderi and Dhundhar. Even the Sultan of Gujarat Bahadur joined Rana Sangha's camp in return for the latter's help in securing the throne of Gujarat.

BATTLE OF KHANWA	
When?	March 1527 CE
Where?	Khanwa, Bharatpur, Rajasthan
Who were the combatants?	
Rajput confederacy	Timurids
Who were the commanders?	
Rana Sangha	Babur
Outcome : Losses suffered on both sides	
SIGNIFICANCE : The introduction of gunpowder and firearms changes the way wars are fought in Bharat.	

On 16 March, 1527 the Rajput army clashed with the entrenched positions of Babur near the village of Khanwa. As Babur notes in Baburnama, the Rajput army numbered around 2 lakh soldiers as compared to 15,000 men in Babur's army. Both sides fought an intense battle with reversing fortunes. Rana Sangha got injured and fell unconscious, quickly taken away from the battlefield by his fellowmen. The Mewar army nevertheless kept fighting. In this battle Mewar lost the best of her sons, but not without inflicting heavy losses on Babur's army.

Both contemporary Rajasthani songs and Muslim records mention that Rana Sangha was preparing for another confrontation with Babur, but he was poisoned by his own noblemen who probably didn't want to fight for a lost cause against Babur and his artillery. Rana Sangha died on 30 January, 1528.

WHAT WENT AGAINST MEWAR

TECHNOLOGY

While the Rajputs relied heavily on their cavalry, especially the war elephants, Babur's army possessed the next generation of weapons technology in the form of cannons and matchlocks. The marauding elephants of the Rajput army were rendered useless against the artillery firepower. Alarmed by the sound of the cannons the elephants retreated, ending up trampling over their own army. The use of gunpowder marked the end of the age of elephants as a weapon in Bharat's warfare.



Officer of Mughal Army with large matchlock

UNITY OF PURPOSE

Babur's army were spurred into action by a common goal, determined to go to any length to execute Babur's orders. On the other side, the Rajput army was huge but lacked solidarity. The Rajput forces were assembled from various alliance partners including Afghans who wanted to restore the Lodi empire. So there was no unity of purpose within the Mewar confederacy that took on Babur.

CLASSROOM DISCUSSION

Is it important for an individual or society or a country to have a unity of purpose, a shared ideal/goal? What are its pros and cons?

LEGACY OF RANA SANGHA

Rana Sangha fought in the battle of Khanwa with one eye, one arm and a limping foot, not to mention dozens of wounds on his body. It's testament to the grandeur of his personality, charisma and valor that despite his handicaps he inspired confidence in the thousands of soldiers to go to war alongside him. Rana Sangha created one of the largest Hindu Kingdom of medieval Bharat, succeeded in uniting the numerous Rajput clans and defeated the Delhi Sultanate.

MEWAR'S PERIOD OF STRUGGLE

The death of Rana Sangha and the subsequent weak leadership and hostility over succession had made Mewar vulnerable to invasion. Mewar, the last bastion of Hindu power in North Bharat was facing existential crisis. Between 1528 CE and 1572 CE Mewar was ruled by Ratna Singh, Vikramaditya, Vanavir and Uday Singh. Mewar kept losing to the forces of the sultan of Gujarat and the Mughals. Chittor was constantly ravaged. It was only in the time of Uday Singh that a second capital was established to reduce the dependence on Chittor. This was the city of Udaipur.

DEVELOPMENTS AFTER RANA SANGHA

AN IMPORTANT ADMINISTRATOR AND RULER - RAJA HEMACHANDRA VIKRAMADITYA


Raja Hemachandra Vikramaditya

There are many accounts of the early years of **Raja Hemachandra** or Raja Hemu as he was popularly known. Hemu's early years were spent in Alwar, Rajasthan where he mastered many languages, the art of war and developed a keen sense for trade. Humayun, the Mughal ruler in Delhi was defeated by Shershah Suri in 1540 CE and driven out of Delhi. Shershah's son Islam Shah took over the throne in 1545 CE at which time Hemu was noticed by Islam Shah for his keen sense of administration and fighting. Being very hard-working and loyal, Hemu quickly rose up the ranks. When Adil Shah Suri took over the throne of Delhi in 1553 CE, Hemu was appointed as Chief Minister and he was the power behind the administration of the Delhi sultanate. Hemu was undefeated in more than 22 battles.

In 1555 CE, Adil Shah was displaced from the throne and the sultanate broke up. Humayun recaptured Delhi and Agra, while Hemu achieved triumph in Bengal. Following Humayun's demise in 1556 CE and Akbar's ascension to the Delhi throne, Hemu rapidly advanced towards Delhi, seizing numerous Mughal-controlled territories along the way. On October 7, 1556 CE, Hemu conquered Delhi, assuming the title of Vikramaditya and earning the name Raja Hemachandra Vikramaditya. This marked a pivotal event where a Hindu ruler assumed control of Delhi, displacing foreign dominion.

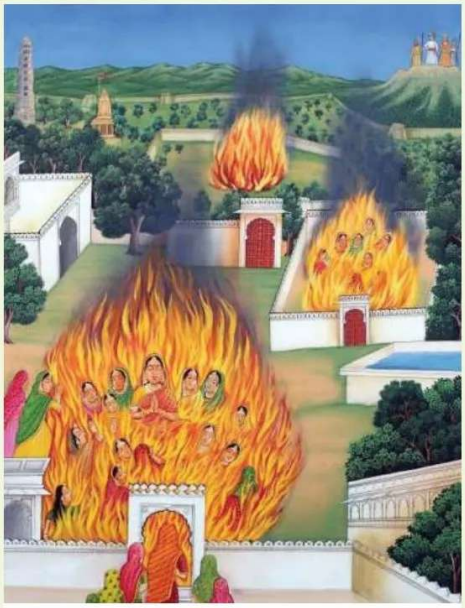
Raja Hemu promptly formulated a plan for administrative enhancement. One month later, Akbar and his armies attacked Delhi, culminating in the second Battle of Panipat on November 5, 1556 CE. Initially securing an advantage, During the battle, a stray arrow blinded Raja Hemu. Despite fighting valiantly, the king fell unconscious and died. The loss of their leader disheartened his army, ultimately concluding the battle. Raja Hemu demonstrated exceptional ambition and bravery, successfully overcoming the foreign rulers who had governed for over a century.

AKBAR'S BRUTAL ASSAULT ON CHITTOR

FANATIC AGGRESSION - 1	
Aggressor	Jalaluddin Akbar
Place / Year	Chittorgarh, Rajasthan / 1567 CE
Defender	Rao Jaimal Rathore, commander of Mewar army
Result of Aggression	About 10,000 soldiers and 30,000 civilians slaughtered 100s of women commit Jauhar

Around this time, a change of guard took place in the Mughal empire. Jalaluddin Akbar ascended the throne in 1556 CE succeeding Humayun. Raja Bharmal of Amber entered an alliance with Akbar by giving his daughter in marriage to Akbar. Thereafter, Raja Bharmal's son and notably his grandson, Maan Singh, joined Akbar's court.

One of the important policy under Akbar was the abolishment of the pilgrim tax in 1563 CE and jizya (a tax paid by non-Muslim subjects to the Muslim rulers) in 1564. This gave relief to the Hindus under his rule, and also won him friendship of Hindu chiefs of Rajasthan. All of this did not make Akbar drop his desire of annexing Rajasthan into the Mughal Empire.



The jauhar of Rajput women at Chittorgarh

Akbar embarked on his Mewar campaign in 1567 CE. On receiving the news of the incoming invasion, Uday Singh summoned the war council. It was clear that the Rajput army, still recovering from the Gujarat wars, could not resist the Mughal army. The king was advised to take refuge in the hills along with the princes, while a contingent commanded by Jaimal Rathore will stay back in Chittor to face Akbar's army. Uday Singh agreed and left for the hills leaving behind 8000 soldiers with Jaimal to guard Chittor.

The army led by Jaimal fought valiantly against Akbar's assault that lasted several weeks. On 23 Feb 1568 CE Akbar was finally successful in breaching the walls of the fort with the help of mines and artillery siege cannons. Jaimal also died in the process that signaled doom to the Rajput defenders. Women and children committed jauhar inside the fort, flames of which were seen by Akbar looking from outside the fort. On 25th Feb, 1568 the Rajput men opened the gates and launched a final assault on Akbar's army and embraced a valorous death with sword in hand. The Mughal soldiers then went on to slaughter 30,000 non-combatants, inhabitants and peasants as ordered by Akbar himself. (as referred to in the Tabaqat-e-Akbari of Nizamudin Bakshi and Akbarnama).

BROKEN MEWAR CONFEDERACY

A year later in 1569 Ranthambore fell into Akbar's hands, and in 1570 Bikaner and Jaisalmer entered into an alliance with Akbar. Uday Singh survived for 4 more years, living in Kumbhalmer. Till the end he refused to surrender to the Mughals unlike other Rajput chieftains who sent their daughters to the Mughal harem. He died on 28 Feb, 1572.

Thus after the Battle of Khanwa, the united confederacy that spanned across Rajasthan was broken. The descendants of the great Rana Kumbha and Rana Sangha will now have to struggle not only against the Mughals but also against the Rajputs to restore the honor of Mewar. In the words of Akbar's courtier Badauni - "a Hindu would wield the sword of Islam". It is under these circumstances that another prodigal son of Mewar, Pratap Singh started his journey.

RANI DURGAVATI



Rani Durgavati took the responsibility of ruling the Gond dynasty and resisting the advances of Akbar and his armies. Born in the Chandela Rajput dynasty to Raja Keerat Rai, she was married into the Gond dynasty. On the loss of her husband Dalpat Shah, she put her infant son on the throne and ruled the kingdom as regent. The Gondwana kingdom stretched over 23,000 villages. A superb administrator and brave warrior, she effectively protected her people from the hostile neighbouring kingdom that was under the Sultan of Malwa and later under Akbar. Their advances were countered by Rani Durgavati. In June 1564, Akbar's armies attacked Gondwana again with a very large force. Rani Durgavati led the battle from the front over several days and lost her life in the battlefield.

RESURGENCE OF MEWAR UNDER MAHARANA PRATAP

MEWAR PREPARES FOR WAR UNDER MAHARANA PRATAP


Maharana Pratap Singh (1540 -1597)

Maharana Pratap Singh took over the reign of Mewar on 1 March 1572 CE. Maharana inherited a wounded empire still recovering from the loss of Chittor to Akbar. Maharana Pratap set out on his plan to fortify Mewar. He vowed to shun all luxury and comfort until Chittor is reclaimed. He made Kumbhalgarh as the state capital and strengthened it. The trade routes that passed through Mewar to the port at Surat were monitored and all Mughal caravans were intercepted and looted.

Maharana also received support from his friends in the Rathore household. Bhaama Shah donated his enormous wealth for the cause of Mewar enabling Maharana to fight the wars that he did. He also received support from Afghan leader Hakim sur Pathan, who was the descendent of Shershah Suri and had an axe to grind with the Mughals. He would die fighting alongside the Rajputs against the Mughal army in the battle of Haldighati.

Most severe of Maharana's policies was to abolish cultivation of land forcing many people to relocate to the Aravali hills. Objective of such a harsh measure was to deny any local food supplies to the Mughal army, thus forcing the Mughals to carry their own supplies when they attacked Mewar. Also the mass slaughter of the common populace by the Turks was now not possible. Movement of population to hills brought them in contact with the mountain dwelling "Bhil" tribe who welcomed them with open arms. Maharana Pratap, his family, the army and the entire population survived several years living on the fruits of the jungles with the help of Bhils. Maharana Pratap reciprocated the warmth of the Bhils by inducting them into his Army to fight as equal partners.

CLASSROOM DISCUSSION

Which country and its populace will abide by a diktat that takes away their livelihood and forces them to migrate? Will it not result in civil war? How grave the situation must have been, how extraordinary a leader Maharana Pratap would have been to convince his subjects to endure this suffering for the cause of Mewar. Discuss

BATTLE OF HALDIGHATI


Maharana Pratap's armour displayed at Udaipur museum

Tension was building up between Akbar and the King of Mewar as multiple diplomatic advances made by Akbar were rendered futile. Maharana refused to bow down to the Mughal throne, and declared Mewar's independence. Failure of diplomatic missions forced Akbar's hand and he ordered an attack on Mewar and assigned Maan Singh as the commanding general of the army.

The battle of Haldighati was fought on 21 June 1576 CE near Gogunda. Maharana who had made Gogunda his temporary capital, had already taken position on the narrow mountain pass (ghati) while Maan Singh had arranged his army in battle formation in the plain below. While the exact numbers on either side are contested, it's clear that the Mewar army was outnumbered.
Maharana Pratap marched with his army in the morning of 21 June, and launched

DID YOU KNOW?

The total weight of Maharana Pratap's armour and weapons was 35 kgs

an attack on the Mughal army. Aware of the large army of the Mughals, Maharana Pratap decided to attack with speed and penetrate the Mughal defenses and end the battle quickly. The vanguard of the Mughal army was blown away by the initial assault by the Rajputs.

But the Rajput rampage was stopped by Maan Singh holding fort at the center of his army. Maharana Pratap rode on his famous steed, Chetak and confronted Maan Singh, who rode an elephant. Maharana threw his javelin at Maan Singh who ducked under it. Meanwhile, Chetak, who was as fearless as his master, placed its forelegs on the elephant and got wounded by the sword tied to the elephant's trunk. Jhala Maan, one of the warriors in the army who bore close resemblance to Maharana, sensed that his King was in danger. He advised Maharana, who was also severely injured by then, to leave the battlefield. Jhala Maan wore Maharana's crown and the Mughal army attacked him mistaking him for Maharana Pratap. A wounded Chetak carried Maharana out of the battlefield and breathed its last only after ensuring his master was out of danger.



Chetak leaping and planting its front legs on the Maan Singh's elephant



Model of Maharana Pratap's horse, Chetak attached with elephant trunk

The Mewar army soon retreated from the battlefield as soon as Maharana had reached safety. Maan Singh desisted from pursuing the army for fear of ambush in the hills. Next day, when the Mughal Army took over Gogunda, the town was empty, with no provisions in store. The Mughal army had to survive on meat and fruits for days. Akbar was disappointed with the result of the battle. He even removed Maan Singh from his court briefly for failing to annihilate the Maharana.

The battle of Haldighati ended in stalemate with neither side achieving its objectives. The battle lasted for a few hours only but was extremely intense. The place came to be known as "Rakht Talai" or the lake of blood, giving a glimpse of the many warriors who died that day.

BATTLE OF HALDIGHATI	
When? June 1576 CE	
Where? Gogunda, Udaipur	
Who were the combatants?	
Mewar Rajputs	Mughals
Who were the commanders?	
Rana Pratap	Akbar, Maan Singh
Outcome : No winner emerges.	
SIGNIFICANCE : Mughals severely routed and a disappointed Akbar removes Maan Singh from his court. Mewar retains its independence.	

BATTLE OF DEWAIR AND THE TRIUMPH OF MAHARANA PRATAP

What followed the battle of Haldighati was Akbar sending his army again and again under different commanders to wrest Mewar from Maharana but with little success. Gogunda was recaptured by Maharana. In September, 1583 the decisive battle of Dewair was fought between the Rajput forces and the Mughal garrison led by Shahbaz Khan. The Mughal army was decimated at Dewair. Maharana pursued the retreating army to Amet and captured the garrison there. Subsequently, Kumbhalemer was captured, 84 garrisons and 36 Mughal outposts were run over by the Rajput army. Mughals had already fled from Udaipur by then.

By 1586, Maharana had captured all of Mewar except Ajmer, Chittor and Mandalgarh. Akbar did not attack Mewar thereafter till the end of his reign. The most powerful ruler of the time gave up on his dream to destroy Maharana Pratap and annex Mewar.

Maharana Pratap died in January 1597 after getting wounded while hunting. Thus ended the life of the greatest hero of medieval Bharat. The consolidation of Mewar during this period, the accumulation of resources and wealth, helped the coming generations under Amar Singh and Raj Singh to fight and defeat Jehangir and Aurangzeb respectively.

BATTLE OF DEWAIR	
When?	September 1583 CE
Where?	Dewair, Mewar
Who were the combatants?	
Rajputs	Mughals
Who were the commanders?	
Rana Pratap	Akbar,Shahbaz Khan
Outcome : Thumping victory of Rajputs	
SIGNIFICANCE : 36,000 Mughal soldiers surrender. 30 Mughal camps destroyed. Mewar retained its independence	



THINK!!!

Have a look at the map. Akbar, with his massive and vast Mughal Empire (shown in green) could not subjugate Maharana Pratap's tiny Mewar (shown in red). For more than 14 years, Maharana Pratap remained unconquered

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CONCLUSION:

Looking back we may think that the Rajputs were involved in a lot of infighting. There are also many instances where their misplaced sense of self-respect led to them giving up their lives and losing ground to adharmic invaders. The Rajputs placed great importance on thseir promises even if the conditions under which such promises were made had greatly changed. This was exploited by their enemies who followed no ethics in the wars.

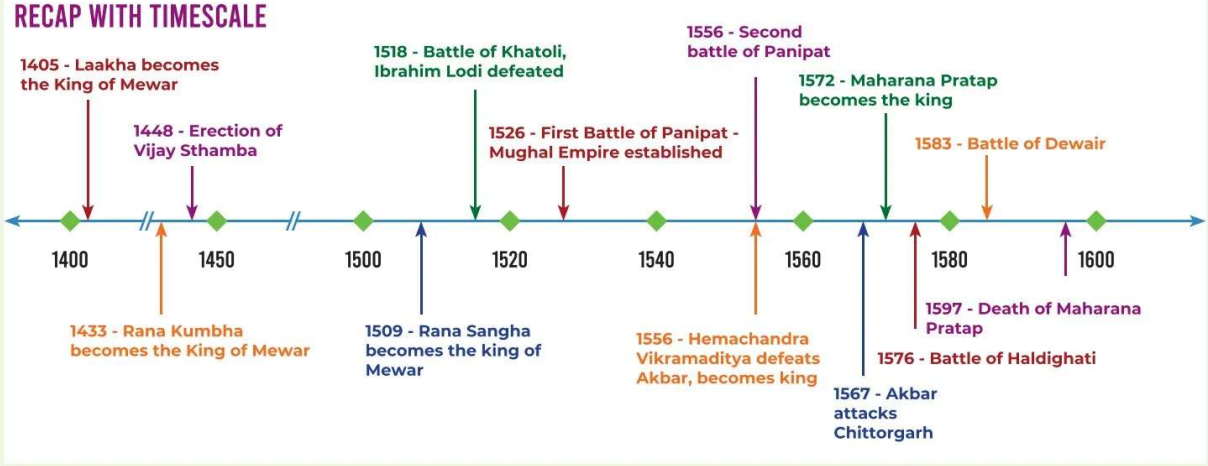
The Rajputs definitely were extraordinary warriors who offered great resistance to the Islamic invaders and preserved the culture of Bharat. The stellar women of the Rajput dynasties were selfless in their bravery and sacrifices that serve to further the might of the Rajputs and their contributions to Bharat.

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KEYWORDS

- Mewar, Marwar
- Rana Sangha
- Rana Kumba
- Raja Hemu
- Sisodias
- Vijay Sthamba
- Battle of Nagaur
- Kumbhalgarh fort
- Mahmud Khalji
- Ibrahim Lodi
- Babur
- First Battle of Panipat
- Khanwa
- Chittorgarh
- Jauhar
- Rani Durgavati
- Rana Pratap, Chetak
- Haldighati
- Dewair

RECAP WITH TIMESCALE



QUESTIONS

MULTIPLE CHOICE QUESTIONS

1. Many Rajputs of the 14th century trace their origins back to the following dynasties.
   a) Pratiharas b) Chandelas c) Paramaras d) All of the above
2. Traders constructed an artificial lake near Udaipur called the _____ lake.
   a) Pushkar b) Pichhola c) Man Sagar d) Dhebar
3. True or False
   Statement A: Raja Lakshasimha married Hamsabai of the Marwar dynasty.
   Statement B: Raja Lakshasimha actively supported HIndu pilgrims who were troubled by the Jaunpur rulers.
   a) A alone is true b) B alone is true c) A & B are false d) A & B are true
4. Rana Kumbha erected the _____, a 37 meter tall monument at Chittorgarh in 1448 CE.
   a) Kirthi sthamba b) Soch sthamba c) Vijay sthamba d) Nirman sthamba
5. The kings of Mewar ruled as representatives of _____.
   a) Rajputs b) Sisodias c) Eklingji d) Paramaras
6. Maharana Pratap vowed to shun all luxuries and comfort until _____ was reclaimed.
   a) Bhilwara b) Jhalawar c) Pratapgarh d) Chittorgarh
7. The Kumbhalgarh fort's citadel located in the Western _____ hills has the second longest wall after the Great wall of China.
   a) Aravalli b) Nilgiri c) Vindhya d) Satpura

REARRANGE THE EVENTS IN CHRONOLOGICAL ORDER

1. a) Rana Sangha becomes ruler of Mewar b) Battle of Khanwa
   c) Battle of Nagaur d) Fall of Delhi sultanate
2. a) Ibrahim Lodi attacks Mewar b) Rayamalla becomes ruler of Mewar
   c) Death of Qutbuddin d) Battle of Dewair

ANSWER BRIEFLY

1. What were Rana Kumbha's contributions to art, literature and religion?
2. Discuss briefly about Rana Sangha's role as a diplomat.

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3. Describe about one ruler of the Gonds.
4. What was the contribution of Jhala Maan to Mewar?
5. Gogunda in Udaipur is known for an important historic event in Mewar's history. What is the event?
6. Under what conditions was Mahmud Khalji released by Rana Sanga?
7. Write a short note about the first battle of Panipat.
8. What was the role of Ranamalla in the life of Rana Kumbha?

ANSWER IN DETAIL

1. What were the reasons that helped Babur win over the Mewar rulers? Discuss.
2. How did Raja Hemachandra become the ruler of Delhi? Why was he known to be a wise ruler and administrator?
3. Why was the battle of Chittorgarh an act of fanatic aggression?
4. What was the impact of the abolition of agricultural activity in Mewar by Maharana Pratap?
5. The battle of Dewair was very significant in the fight between the Rajputs and Mughals. Why?
6. A lack of unity leads to external aggressions. Explain this statement in the context of Mewar and Mrwar.

CASE STUDY

"The descendants of the great Rana Kumbha and Rana Sangha will now have to struggle not only against the Mughals but also against the Rajputs to restore the honour of Mewar. In the words of Akbar's courtier Badauni - "a Hindu would wield the sword of Islam". It is under these circumstances that another prodigal son of Mewar, Pratap Singh started his journey."

1. What are the reasons for the struggle of Rana Kumbha's descendants?
2. Discuss the major event that led to a state of disunity among the Rajputs.

MAP ACTIVITY:

Mark the places on an outline map of Bharat:

• Udaipur • Sirohi • Gujarat • Marwar • Mewar • Chittorgarh

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